

Look ma no wires!

Agent 001 goes hunting for the best Wi-Fi routers in town

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A trend I've been observing for sometime now is home users increasingly going in for Wi-Fi routers. This rise can be attributed to a couple of use case scenarios. People now have multiple browsing devices at home – most commonly laptops, while some even connect via mobile phones and high end PMPs such as the iPod Touch. Obviously, connecting to the internet from any part of your home, say from the comfort of your couch or the picturesque beauty of your balcony, is a tempting proposition. Another factor for increase in the offtake of this product category is that high-end users have started to set up purpose specific rigs such as download or media center rigs at home and don't want the cable clutter that comes along with it. Besides, the price drop and implementation of the 802.11n make this perhaps the perfect time to go in for a Wi-Fi router.

That being said the world of Wi-Fi routers is a little complex, simply because of the various types of routers available; each with a specific purpose, performance level and price range.

For instance, there are routers that come with a USB port – to share flash drives, Dual Band, and even torrent downloading features. Buying a Wi-Fi router hence can be as simple as going over to the nearest electronics/hardware shop and announcing to the shopkeeper "Give me one Wi-Fi router", or it can be a nerve wracking process filled with choices and options. No self-respecting Digit reader is going to go for the first option. No wonder

I've been getting so many mails regarding Wi-Fi routers. So I decided to take a little trip down to the local electronics market to check out what was available and give you a bit of gyan on choosing the right Wi-Fi router for your needs.

At the first shop that I went to, I put on my poker face and did what most consumers do, "*Ek Wi-Fi router dena*". The shopkeeper plonked the Belkin G Wireless Router and nonchalantly stated the price, Rs 1350. On getting a similar response at most places I went to, with shop guys either pushing either the aforementioned Belkin or the Netgear G54 (₹1550), I could easily deduce that they're trying to get rid of the outdated their stock of routers based on the older

and inferior 802.11g standard. The g routers are cheap yes, but offer a maximum speed of 54Mbps. This is fine if you're sole purpose is browsing and the area that you require to be covered is relatively small, say a maximum of two small rooms, separated by a thin wall. The moment you enter into the territory of media streaming or if your home is a duplex with rooms not adja-

cent but one above the other, you need to go for an N router. These routers offer a wider range and the N standard supports speeds of upto 600Mbps. They don't cost a whole lot more either, the cheapest N router I found was the Digisol DG-BR4000N for ₹1650 and it came with a warranty. Since the brand is an offshoot of D-Link, service and quality should not be a problem. This mean that for just a ₹300 increase in



your budget you get better range and faster speeds. The other N-supported routers that was easily available over-the-counter was the Belkin N150 for Rs 1850 – a decent performer in our recent Wi-Fi test. When it came to routers with a USB port that facilitate sharing content from a portable drive, the market seems to have only one option over-the-counter, the Belkin N+ for ₹4550.

If you have a higher budget, you can look at the higher-end routers in the July issue. These are feature rich in terms of the interface, design and other factors. But since they're not easily available your best bet is to look for them in online shops or have them specifically ordered through your local store. One such router is the Asus RT-N16, which is a robust performer and has features like torrent downloading, FTP and P2P all for ₹6,600. The Linksys WRT610N, priced around ₹9,400 is a dual-band router, which means that it supports the lesser used 5Ghz frequency range. It also has options to set traffic priority to certain applications for better performance – good for gamers.

For those looking for ADSL routers, the Linksys WAG160N for ₹6,500 is a good option. It comes with an ADSL



Asus RT N16

component built into it, so you can get rid of the ADSL modem that your ISP provides (and probably charges you rent for), plus reduce the device clutter. It also has an option to use one of the other LAN ports as a WAN connection if you choose to move to an ISP that uses Ethernet to distribute connections.

My little trip down to Lamington Road has proved useful and will definitely help out those of you who have been writing to me with your Wi-Fi woes. Remember you have many options, simply assess your need and choose the right product.



Belkin N150